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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Knowledge Paralegal role in A&O Shearman's Global Financial Markets group because finance work is an area I have been actively building towards, and this role sits at the point where legal knowledge meets practical deal support in a way that genuinely interests me.

My interest in financial markets law developed concretely at A&O Shearman's open day in August 2026, where a private equity session and a finance workshop showed me how different practice areas contribute to a transaction and how lenders take security, including in asset-specific contexts like aircraft and ship financing. That session prompted me to take a Coursera course on private equity, covering fund structures, leverage, value creation and exit strategies, so I could better understand the commercial mechanics behind the legal work. I am not claiming a long-standing background in finance law, but I have followed the interest up deliberately rather than just noting it.

The skills the role draws on are ones I have used in practice. At BCLP I worked across a year-long placement in international arbitration and real estate disputes, where I maintained structured electronic case files in iManage, tracked procedural deadlines across multiple matters, and coordinated documents under time pressure shortly before a significant arbitration submission. That kind of file and deadline management is directly relevant to supporting a busy transactional team. I also drafted procedural documents, prepared hearing bundles and conducted legal research on substantive points, so I am comfortable with the kind of document handling and research a knowledge paralegal role involves.

At Citizens Advice, where I currently advise clients across welfare, employment and housing matters, I translate complex statutory rules into practical written guidance and manage matters from initial instruction to submission. Working with clients on sensitive, high-stakes problems has sharpened how I communicate clearly under pressure, which is relevant wherever a role involves coordinating between lawyers and clients or external parties.

What draws me specifically to this role at A&O Shearman rather than another finance team is that the GFM group works across practice areas and jurisdictions on market-shaping deals. My LLM in Comparative and International Dispute Resolution has given me a grounding in cross-border legal analysis, and seeing how A&O lawyers discussed their work at the open day made clear this is a team that takes the development of its people seriously. This role is a logical next step for me.

Yours sincerely,
Maria Silva